

Hardware303

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I have implemented a partial replica of the Roland TB-303 in VHDL. The Roland TB-303 is an analog bass line synthesizer noted for its characteristic filter - a diode ladder filter - that is hard to replicate in software. This design uses a Moog ladder filter however, since it is much more well known, and does not require significant analog analysis to replicate the sound of the TB-303 as a diode ladder would.

Theory of Operation

Basic Blocks

The Roland TB-303 consists of the following blocks: - Oscillator: a voltage-controlled oscillator that creates a square or sawtooth wave in the bass clef range. - Filter: a resonant low-pass filter meant to mimic the sound of a Moog ladder filter, but using diodes instead of BJTs for the active component of the filter. - Sequencer: a small bank of memory and logic that generates the frequencies to be produced by the oscillator. - VCA: a voltage controlled amplifier used to control the dynamics (volume before, during, and after a note is played). The TB-303 has the controls of ADSR (attack, delay, sustain, and release).

Thus, the Hardware 303 should implement the digital equivalent of each of these blocks. That is,

- A numerically controlled oscillator that takes an integer and produces both a square and sawtooth wave of the desired frequency.
- A Moog ladder filter that models the dynamics of the analog filter.
- A sequencer that generates integers according to a user input pattern.
- A NCA (numerically controlled amplifier) that prescales the output according to the desired setting.

<insert schematic of TB-303 ???>

In this project, an NCO and filter were implemented and tested in VHDL.

NCO

An NCO capable of outputting a square and sawtooth wave essentially consists of an adder, a comparator, and a few registers to accumulate the added value. The input word is added each clock period, and if a sawtooth waveform is desired, we just output the accumulated value. If a square wave output is desired, we simply threshold the accumulated value according to our desired duty cycle. More complex NCOs included phase control word inputs in addition to frequency control inputs, allowing the user to shift the phase when desired. If a sine wave is desired, a lookup table mapping an accumulated value to an output value can be implemented.

The NCO was tested over the bass clef range by logging the output word at each clock cycle to a text file. This text file was then analyzed with a Python script, `verify_nco.py`. This generates both a time and frequency domain plot for each output frequency. We also programmatically verify that besides just the fundamental frequency being correct, the spectral contents of the waveform are what we expect for a square and sawtooth wave. A perfect square wave will contain only odd harmonics, while a sawtooth wave will include all harmonics. The harmonics of both will decay at a rate of 6dB / octave.

Filter

A resonant low-pass filter is simply a low-pass filter that produces The filter is based on the Huovilainen's paper titled "NON-LINEAR DIGITAL IMPLEMENTATION OF THE MOOG LADDER FILTER" [1], in which the author approximates the non-linearities

[1] https://dafx.de/paper-archive/2004/P_061.PDF